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Focus on · briefing
Issue 4 · 6 November 2026
robertjpark.co.uk

FOCUS ON METALS & MANUFACTURING · 6 NOVEMBER 2026

Industry emissions are down 69% since 1990. Now borders and customers want the numbers.

Making things for two markets: what UK CBAM, EU customer demands and carbon-market linking mean for Northern Ireland manufacturers.

By Robert J. Park · robertjpark.co.uk · WhatsApp @robertjpark

−69%
fall in NI industry emissions since 1990

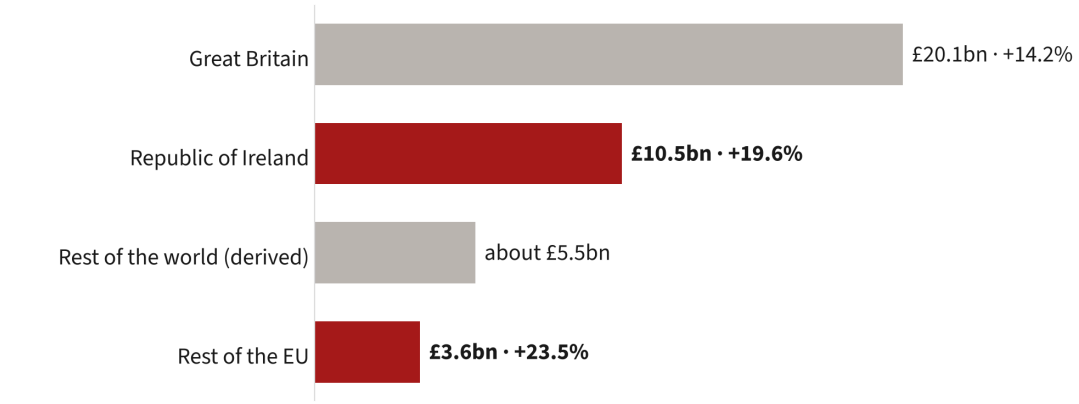
1 Jan 2027
UK carbon border levy (CBAM) starts

£14.1bn
NI sales to the EU in 2024, £10.5bn of it to the Republic of Ireland

£50,000
of covered imports in 12 months triggers UK CBAM registration

£20.1bn to Great Britain, £14.1bn to the EU

Sales by NI businesses outside Northern Ireland, 2024 (£ billion), with change on 2023. Red: EU markets.



Source: DfE/NISRA, NI Economic Trade Statistics 2024 (11 March 2026). All NI businesses. Rest of world derived.

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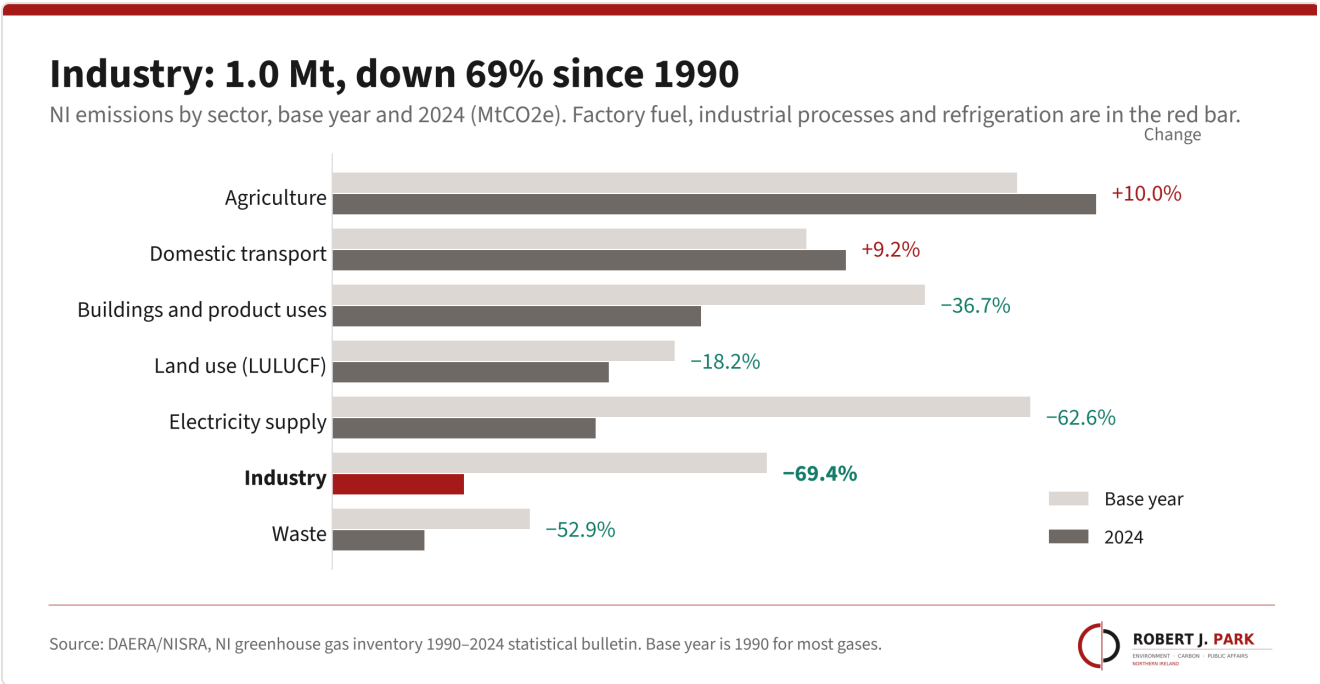
Sales outside NI by NI businesses, 2024. Source: DfE/NISRA, NI Economic Trade Statistics 2024.

Northern Ireland industry emitted 3.3 million tonnes of CO2e in 1990. By 2024 it was 1.0 million, a fall of 69%. Manufacturing is about one in ten NI jobs and sells both ways: £20.1bn of NI sales went to Great Britain in 2024 and £14.1bn to the EU. From 1 January the UK's carbon border levy applies to imported steel, aluminium, cement, fertiliser and hydrogen, and EU customers already ask NI suppliers for emissions data. Manufacturers that can show their numbers will keep their contracts.

WHERE EMISSIONS SIT

Fuel switching did the heavy lifting

Industry in the NI inventory covers fuel burned in factories and on construction sites, industrial processes and industrial refrigeration. The long-term fall came mostly from food and drink, chemicals and cement, helped by the switch from coal and oil to natural gas. Electricity is counted separately: half of NI's electricity now comes from renewables, against a legal target of 80% by 2030, so Scope 2 emissions should keep falling.



NI emissions by sector, base year and 2024 (MtCO2e). Source: DAERA/NISRA GHG inventory 1990–2024.

THE BORDER

UK CBAM starts on 1 January

From 1 January 2027, UK importers of iron and steel, aluminium, cement, fertiliser and hydrogen from outside the UK and EU pay a carbon levy. Glass and ceramics are left out at the start, and so are indirect emissions until 2029 at the earliest. The rules are now law: the Emissions and Verification Regulations (SI 2026/995) were made on 8 September and come into force on 1 January. The 28 October Budget confirmed that default values will be a single global figure per good in 2027 and 2028, then country-specific from 2029.

- Registration is triggered once covered imports reach £50,000 in any 12 months, or are expected to within the next 30 days.
- HMRC's registration service opens on 1 January 2028. Businesses that pass the threshold in 2027 have until 31 January 2028 to register, so keep records of every covered import from 1 January.
- The first return and payment, for 2027, are due by 31 May 2028.

For an NI fabricator buying steel sections, bar or aluminium extrusions from Turkey, China or India, this is a new cost and a new data request to suppliers. Goods bought from GB or the EU are outside UK CBAM.

TWO MARKETS

EU customers ask for data

The EU's own CBAM entered its definitive phase on 1 January 2026. It does not apply in Northern Ireland: it is not among the EU laws the Windsor Framework applies here. But EU buyers with obligations of their own ask their suppliers for embedded emissions data, and an NI business selling on delivered duty paid (DDP) terms acts as the importer in the EU, so should check with its customs agent whether any CBAM duty falls to it.

Linking the carbon markets. In October the UK and EU were reported to have agreed how to link their emissions trading schemes, but neither side has confirmed it. Leaders meet at the UK–EU summit on 20 November, where the link is expected alongside the agri-food deal. Once linking is in force, goods covered by both CBAMs would be exempt from each other's charges, with less paperwork. Until then, plan for both regimes. I will update this briefing after the summit.

REPORTING

Fewer legal duties, more questions

The EU's sustainability reporting rules (CSRD) now apply only to groups with more than 1,000 employees and €450m turnover, and limit what they can demand from suppliers with fewer than 1,000 staff. The UK published its own Sustainability Reporting Standards in February 2026 for voluntary use; no mandatory date has been set.

ESOS energy audits remain compulsory for large businesses: the phase 4 qualification date is 31 December 2026, and notification is due by 5 December 2027.

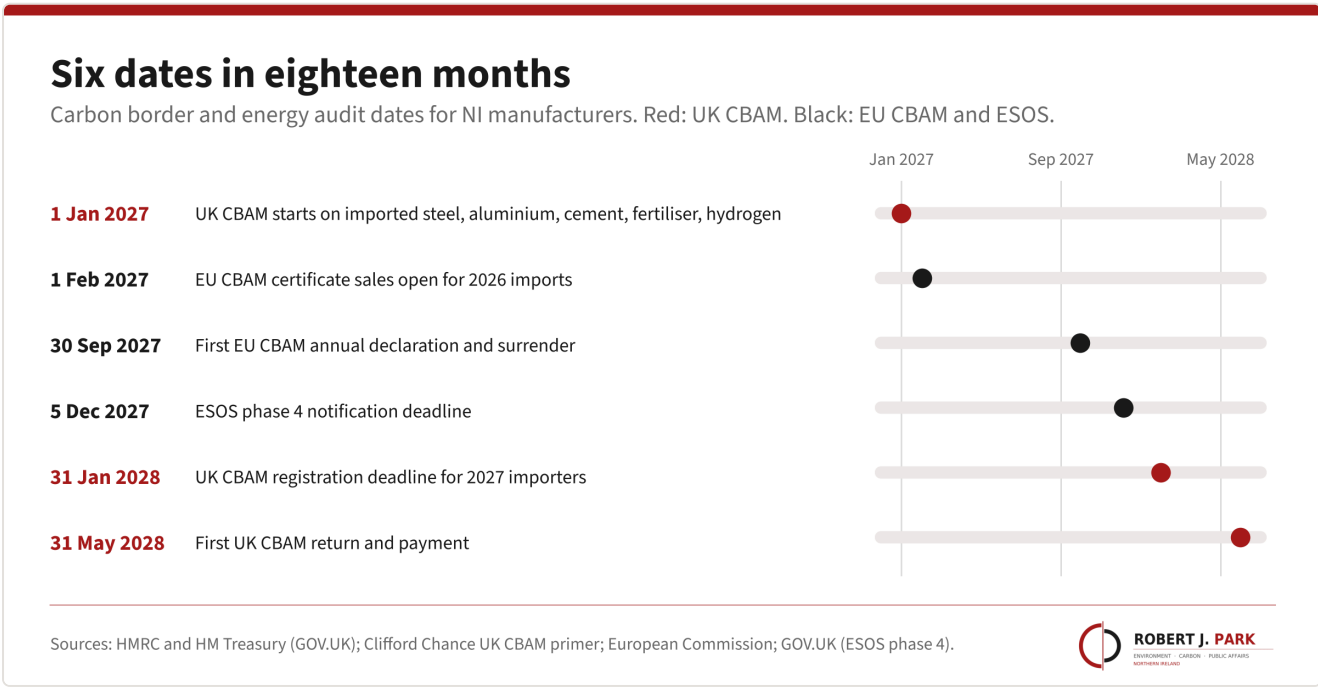
ENERGY

Your biggest controllable carbon cost

For most NI manufacturers, compressed air, process heat, motors and refrigeration make up most of the energy bill. Compressed-air leak surveys, variable speed drives, heat recovery and better controls usually pay back fastest. Invest NI's Energy Efficiency Capital Grant is paused while it is reviewed, so plan projects that stand up on their own.

POLICY AND DEADLINES

Six dates in eighteen months



Carbon border and ESOS dates for NI manufacturers, January 2027 to May 2028.

WHEN	WHAT	WHO IT AFFECTS
20 Nov 2026	UK–EU summit: emissions trading link expected	All NI manufacturers
1 Jan 2027	UK CBAM starts	Importers of covered goods from outside the UK and EU
1 Feb 2027	EU CBAM certificate sales open for 2026 imports	EU importers
30 Sep 2027	First EU CBAM annual declaration and surrender	EU importers
5 Dec 2027	ESOS phase 4 notification deadline	Large businesses
31 Jan 2028	UK CBAM registration deadline for 2027 (registration opens 1 Jan 2028)	Importers that passed £50,000 in 2027
31 May 2028	First UK CBAM return and payment	Registered importers

THIS MONTH

Three things a manufacturer can do

1. Pull last year's purchase ledger and total your imports of steel, aluminium, cement, fertiliser and hydrogen by country of origin. If non-UK, non-EU imports could reach £50,000 in any 12 months from January, start keeping CBAM records now.
2. Check the Incoterms on your EU sales. If you sell DDP, you act as the importer in the EU: ask your customs agent whether any CBAM duty falls to you.

3. Prepare a one-page product carbon statement (Scope 1 and 2 per tonne or per unit) so you can answer customer questionnaires quickly and consistently.

See the numbers behind this briefing

The NI Metals and Manufacturing dashboard sets out every figure used here: industry emissions against other sectors, where NI sales go, which goods each CBAM covers, the CBAM and ESOS dates, and progress on renewable electricity. Each chart can be downloaded as a CSV.

Open the dashboard

Which rules apply to you?

The free Incoterms Chooser finds the right Incoterms 2020 rule in four questions and flags NI, customs and CBAM points. The ESG Regime Tracker shows which UK, NI and EU carbon and sustainability rules apply to your business.

Try the Incoterms Chooser · Open the ESG Regime Tracker

Reading these figures with care

- **Inventory sectors.** The Industry figure covers all manufacturing and construction. Electricity is counted under electricity supply.
- **Trade figures** are for all NI businesses, not manufacturing alone. "One in ten jobs" is Manufacturing NI's figure from ONS data for 2023.
- **CBAM rules.** UK CBAM rules were checked against HMRC guidance on 5 November 2026; the 31 January 2028 deadline for 2027 importers is as reported by Clifford Chance. Check HMRC guidance before relying on any date.
- **Carbon-market linking** is reported, not confirmed, until the UK and EU announce it.

SOURCES

Where the figures come from

- NI greenhouse gas inventory 1990–2024 statistical bulletin (DAERA/NISRA)
- NI Economic Trade Statistics 2024 (DfE/NISRA, 11 March 2026)
- Manufacturing and the Northern Ireland Economy (Manufacturing NI, May 2025)
- Factsheet: Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (HM Treasury and HMRC, GOV.UK)
- Check if you'll need to register for CBAM (HMRC, GOV.UK)
- Work out the date you'll need to register for CBAM (HMRC, GOV.UK, updated 20 October 2026)
- The Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (Emissions and Verification) Regulations 2026, SI 2026/995
- Budget 2026, HC 726, para 6.217 (HM Treasury, 28 October 2026)
- 2026 UK CBAM primer (Clifford Chance, September 2026)
- CBAM for Northern Ireland businesses (April 2026)
- CBAM for NI businesses (nibusinessinfo, March 2026)
- ETS linkage agreed, as reported by The Day in Trade (Institute of Export & International Trade, 8 October 2026)
- UK–EU linking deal reported, summit hinges on other files (Veyt, 8 October 2026)
- EU Sustainability Omnibus (Latham & Watkins)
- Final UK Sustainability Reporting Standards (HSF Kramer, March 2026)
- ESOS phase 4 (GOV.UK)

- Electricity consumption and renewable generation, year ending June 2026 (DfE)
- Energy Efficiency Capital Grant (Invest NI)

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Focus on is a briefing by Robert J. Park, an independent environment, carbon and public-affairs consultant based in Larne, Northern Ireland. Robert helps manufacturers build carbon inventories, plan UK and EU CBAM obligations, deliver ESOS with Lead Assessors, and answer customer carbon questionnaires.

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